

Medieval Europe

After the fall of the Roman Empire, Europe fragmented into many small states in which local leaders took power and, in some cases, carved out empires for themselves. The Frankish ruler Charlemagne and the Saxon Otto I both held territory that approached the size and power of the Western Roman Empire.

The most successful of the new states to emerge in the period after the end of the Western Roman Empire was the kingdom of the Franks. The Franks were a confederacy of Germanic tribes from the area around modern-day Belgium and Holland. Under their leader Clovis (c. 481–511 CE), the Franks conquered most of the old Roman province of Gaul and laid the foundations of an empire that would dominate Western Europe for centuries. Significantly for the future of Europe, Clovis also

converted to Catholic Christianity while most of his rivals were Arians, regarded as heretics by the Roman population. In doing so, Clovis ensured that Catholicism, rather than the Arian form of Christianity, would eventually prevail through Western Europe. On his death, Clovis's kingdom was divided among his sons, and it continued to expand in the 6th century under his descendants, known as the Merovingians.

The Carolingians

The power of the Frankish kings declined in the late 7th century. Several died young, and rival aristocratic factions vied for

power. One of these families, later known as the Carolingians, emerged as dominant as a result of the alliances with other noble houses made by its head, Pippin II. From 719 to 741 CE his illegitimate son Charles Martel ("the Hammer") controlled the kingdom, ruling in the name of a succession of Merovingian kings. Charles Martel defeated Arab raids from Spain and reimposed Frankish rule east of the Rhine. Anglo-Saxon missionaries such as St. Boniface were encouraged to set up monasteries and promote conversion in the conquered territories. In 751, Charles Martel's son Pippin III obtained the pope's approval to depose the last Merovingian king, and became the first ruler of the new Carolingian dynasty.

Charlemagne

Pippin's son, Charles the Great or Charlemagne, reigned for almost half a century from 768. He faced few internal challenges to his authority and was able to initiate a series of aggressive campaigns against the neighboring

4,500 pagan Saxon prisoners were beheaded on a single day in 782 CE, according to one contemporary chronicle, after the emperor Charlemagne ordered them to choose between Christian baptism and execution.

peoples. The king met with the leading lay and ecclesiastical nobles in an annual assembly each spring, in which new laws were agreed and plans made for campaigning later in the year. Frankish society was organized for almost continuous warfare, and the nobles depended on conquest for a continuing supply of treasure and new territories with which to support and expand their own followings.

Under Charlemagne, the Franks undertook 30 years of warfare against the pagan Saxon tribes to the east of the Frankish lands, forcefully converting them to Christianity. In 773, invited by Pope Hadrian I to save Rome from conquest by the Lombard (north Italian) king Desiderius, Charlemagne invaded northern Italy. Following the capture of the capital, Pavia, he proclaimed himself King of the

Lombards. An expedition to the Ebro Valley in Spain in 778 was less successful, but Charlemagne's greatest triumph came in 796 with the collapse of the Avar Empire, centered in modern Hungary, as a result of Frankish attacks. He acquired the enormous treasure they had built up over the preceding three centuries, which he used to

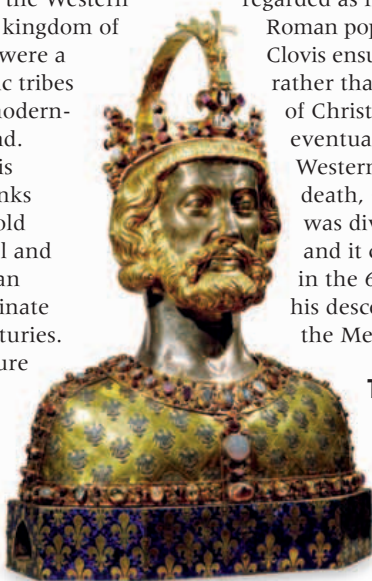
pay for new churches and monasteries, as well as building a new capital at Aachen in western Germany.

The Carolingian renaissance

Contacts with Italy and the Anglo-Saxon kingdoms enabled Charlemagne to attract scholars to his court, such as Alcuin of York, the Visigothic poet Theodulf, and the Lombard historian Paul the Deacon. Not only did the Frankish court become a center of learning to which the leading aristocratic

families sent their sons, these and other advisors also helped Charlemagne to carry out a program of reform of the Frankish church. This involved importing model texts from Italy, including works of liturgy, church law, monastic rule, and biblical scholarship. Higher levels of literacy were imposed on the clergy, and new laws were issued throughout the reign to counter errors and abuses in the Frankish church. A reformed and more legible script known as Caroline replaced that used in the Merovingian period, and continued in use throughout Western Europe until the 12th century.

In 802 CE, following the failure of two rebellions against him, Charlemagne imposed oaths of loyalty on all free men over the age of 12. His subjects swore loyalty to "my lord Charles, most



Charlemagne reliquary
This silver container, made in the shape of a bust of the emperor, was reputed to have contained parts of his skull.

BEFORE

As the power of the Roman Empire came to an end, other leaders took control of the areas that had been controlled by Rome.

WANING OF THE ROMAN EMPIRE

Over the course of the 5th century CE, **military and economic problems** led to the western Roman emperors being **unable to exercise direct rule** over their provinces **◀ 150–51**. Instead, power was delegated to a series of commanders from beyond the frontiers who established themselves with their followers. Rome lost control of **Britain** in around 410, **Southern and Western Spain** in 413, **Southwest France** in 418, **North France and the rest of Spain** after 451, and most of the **rest of France** in 473. Romulus Augustulus, the last Roman emperor, was deposed in 476 by **Odoacer**, leader of a federation of East Germanic tribes. Odoacer was crowned King of Italy.

POWER IN THE EAST AND WEST

Barbarians filled the power vacuum left by the end of the Western Empire in the 5th–6th centuries: **Visigoths** in Spain, **Ostrogoths** in Italy, **Vandals** in North Africa, **Anglo-Saxons** in England, and **Franks** in Gaul (France).

The Eastern Roman Empire survived and became known as the empire of Byzantium **198–99▶**, although further provinces were lost to Slavs in the Balkans and the Arabs in the Mideast and Africa in the 6th–7th centuries.

